

Interview >> **MALCOLM SPEED**

"The financial potential of Twenty20 is huge"

ICC Chief Executive Officer Malcolm Speed spoke to Deputy Editor SHARDA UGRA on the impact and future of Twenty20 cricket. Excerpts.

Q. People are calling Twenty20 the future of the game? Does that sound ominous to you?

A. No. It is a great opportunity for us to blend a new format of the game with Test and ODI cricket. We are very excited about the success of this tournament and the success of Twenty20 at the domestic level. We encourage this format at the state, county and provincial level because it is difficult to draw crowds there. With T20 we are able to do that.

Q. What was the rationale behind holding this event at this particular point of time when most countries barely play T20?

A. First, we are at the start of a new group of the International Cricket Council; we are now starting with ESPNStar Sports and a new group of sponsors. I was keen to do it this year. I felt ICC needed to put its stamp on the international component of T20 before someone else—a television network or an entrepreneur—tried to do the same. We decided on South Africa as the host because they are very enthusiastic about T20 cricket.

Q. There is a fear that T20 will erode traditional cricket skills.

A. I wrote a paper for the ICC board about T20 in which I had said that we were not asking cricket players to learn to play polo or chess. We were only asking them to use the same skills for 20 overs rather than for 50 overs. As I sat there watching Yuvraj Singh hitting six sixes in one over, I knew he had

adapted to the game pretty well.

Q. Are you trying to stop it from taking over everything else?

A. We want T20 primarily to be played at the state, county and provincial level. The Indian Premier League is a good example of what we are trying to do there. It's a short sharp league with some international but mainly domestic players. We are bringing forward a new generation of players who are going to have a professional career and are going to be able to play in high-profile events. At the international level, we will have the ICC World T20 every two or three years. We have limited the number of matches they can play at home. So from April to March, India can play three T20 internationals at home, and when they are touring, they can play four.

Q. What is the financial potential of T20 for cricket?

A. We did a study three years ago, which showed that 64 per cent of our television revenue comes from ODIs and 36 per cent from Test cricket. So a 50-over format is the financial driver of world cricket. Now, maybe 10 per cent will come from T20 and hopefully, the pile will grow. The financial potential of T20 is huge. The television rights from T20 events are going to be significant, and that goes back to the boards. The total revenue of ICC for this event this time was between \$50 million and \$60 million.

monitor their heart-beats during a game, with readings put up for display on TV every time a match gets tight.

This device has also helped understand why players, who could easily compete for seven hours on a field now stagger off after a Twenty20 game that takes less than half the time, feeling as if they had been tackling a commando course rather a cricket match.

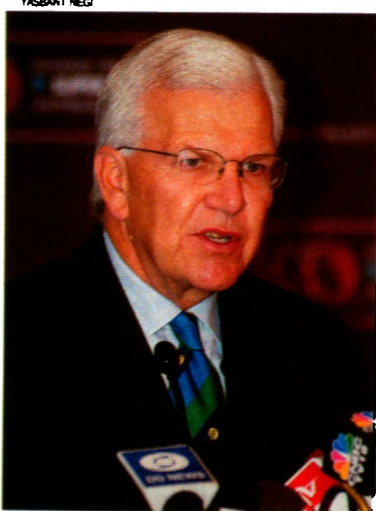
When India captain Dhoni said he found the game more intense than an ODI or a day in a Test, he wasn't overstating the demands of the job. Shayamal Vallabhjee, physical trainer for the Nashua Dolphins team based in Durban, says the intensity of the T20 format does two things to a cricketer's body: the game situation causes the body to produce high quantities of nervous adrenaline, which then boosts

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<< **IRFAN PATHAN, BOWLER**

the heart rate. Vallabhjee says, "Batsmen who are fit by international standards are operating at 90 per cent of their maximum heart rate in Twenty20. It means that a player's heart is going at 160 beats a minute if he's fit, 190 if he's not fit and I've even seen it touch 200 in some games. As there's adrenaline flowing all the time, players are operating at this heart rate for a longer period of time." Players walk off after a close game feeling like they have run a marathon. Twenty20 is not just a game of cricket; it is an intensive cardio workout.

The players' community has mixed feelings about T20. The Australians, champions in all forms but this, seemed almost English in their reluctance to give it a vote of approval. Adam Gilchrist admitted to "wrestling" with it in his mind. In the early stages of the event, the Australian wicket-keeper had said, "The more I play it, I am starting to, not so much like it as a player, but love watching it." After the defeat to India, he concluded, "It will help improve one-day cricket." T20 has made titans struggle like mortals. In a game dominated by Australia for almost a decade now, T20 had become



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